

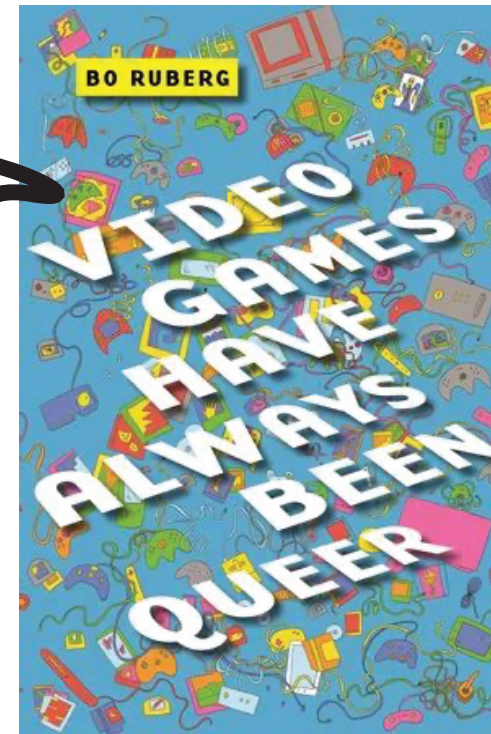
Game Design Research: using intentional error to relay queerness

Researched by Ashlynnne McBride

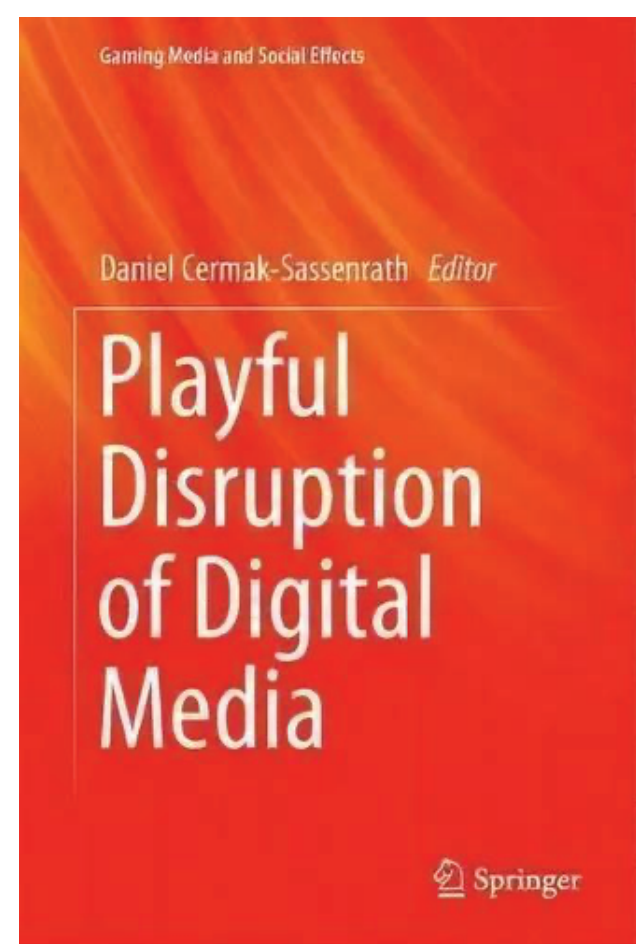
Mentored by Dr. Ari Gass

Background

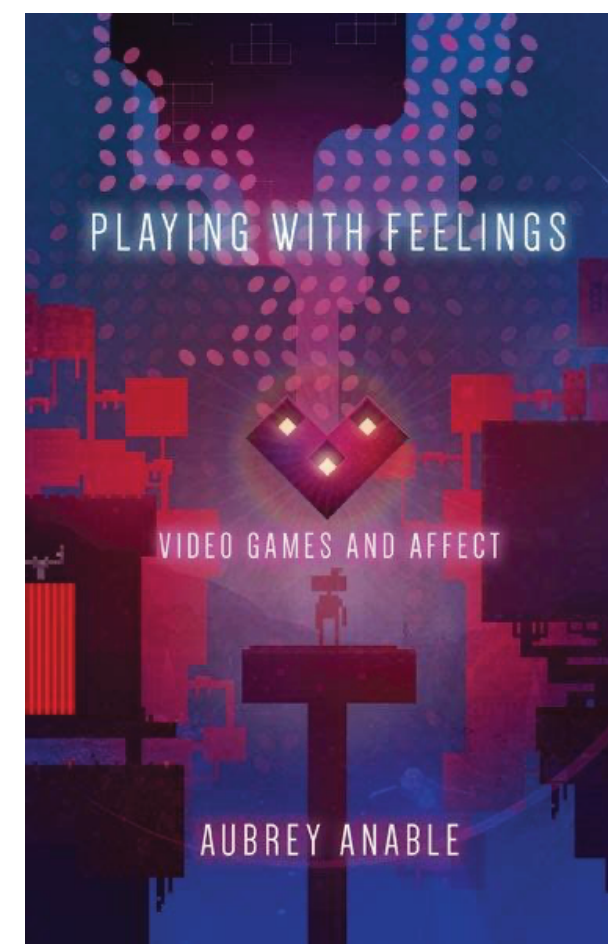
"playing queer is itself a playful and creative act—an approach to finding alternative ways of being, doing, and making meaning in games that has the potential to resonate powerfully with queer subjects" (Ruberg 2019)



"Games grant us agency to enact our proposed solutions and give us feedback to reflect on their consequences."



"what affect names is a way of talking about the myriad of ways everyday experience is felt but is not articulated or is inarticulable."



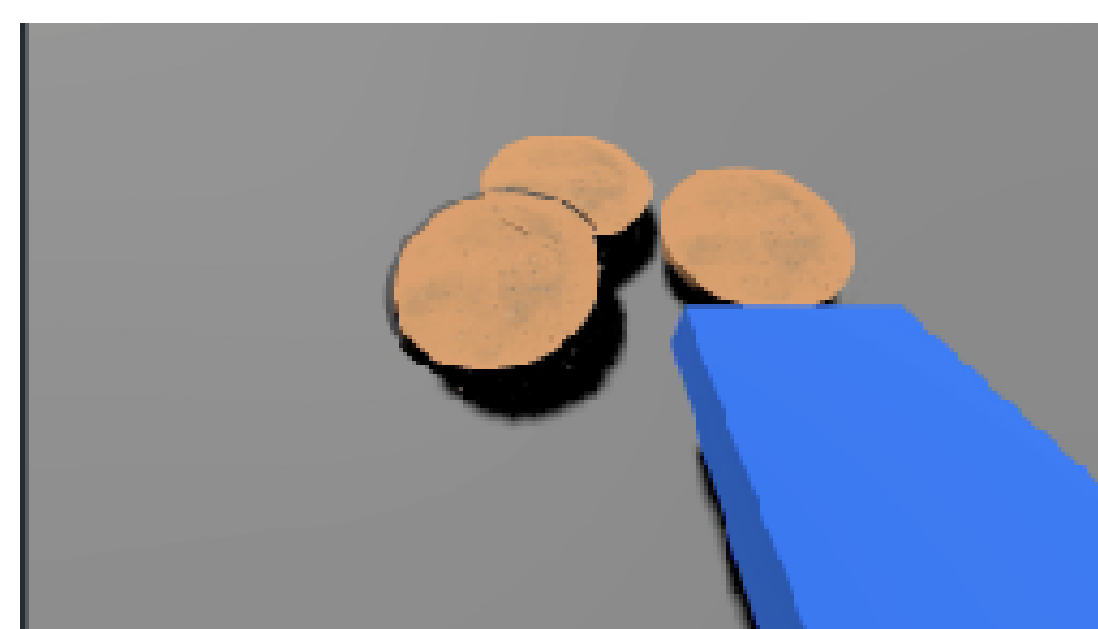
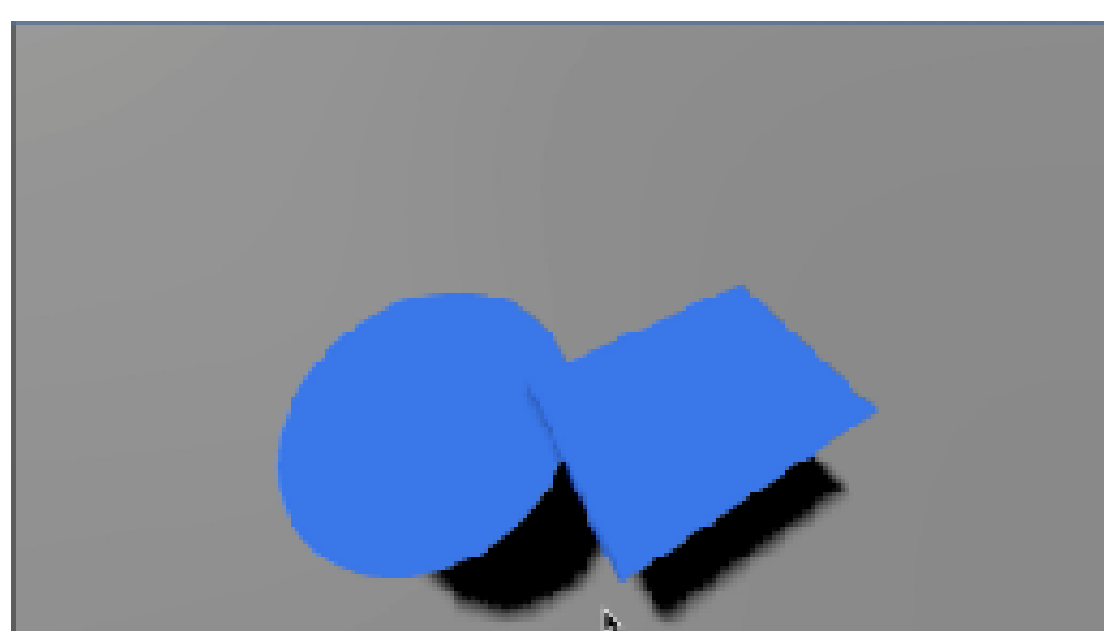
Introduction

Queerness is an identity, but it's also an experience. The conveyance of queerness in video games isn't always with queer character representation, it can also be evident in the structure of games made by queer creators. The modern ideal for a "good" game entails instant reactions, precise collisions, and understandable controls—challenging this status quo is the basis for queer game studies. During this research, I used reflective design principles, detailed by Kaled et al. Reflection is an evolutionarily useful skill; we use our past experiences to create a solutions to new encounters or to develop new opinions. Games are low consequence areas to practice problem solving skills. Reflective learning in real life means making critical mistakes (worst of which could be social blunders, losing a job, etc). In a game, consequences don't matter and therefore are more free. This is a game that uses glitched gameplay to make a game intended to invoke frustration, pressure, unfairness, and unconventionally "not fun" feelings. We have these feelings in everyday life, why are games expected to take us away from them as opposed to acting as tools to explore them? I made this game with the intention of inviting the player to reflect on what the game means to them.

Methods

- Examined works intersecting queer theory with game studies to orient to existing research
- Applied affect theory to critically view the intersectional experiences of myself and potential players in order to break bias chains
- Conducted iterative playtesting of video game demo to fine tune the mechanics to convey the correct feeling of play
- Utilized Claude to optimize time spent problem solving in engine
- Designed 3D game mechanics using Godot, an open-source game engine
- Maintained a proper version control organization system on GitHub, a standard practice essential in the industry.
- Followed Reflective Game Design ^1 (Kaled) practices in order to slow down the creation process and make each design decision intentional

Iteration



playtesting, photos
from that, changes
from that

Conclusion

Being queer is both an identity and an experience, and viewing games in this light can make the experience of interacting with them queer. Game studies as a whole needs to open its doors to the various affects of players, as for too long the industry has assumed a deeply societally biased stereotype of player to cater towards. My goal with this project is to encourage players to form their own opinions and experiences in order to break down traditional ideals of the "perfect player" and what a "good game" has to be. By representing a non-conventional and inherently queer point of view, I hope to invite individuals of many different intersectionalities to participate in the discussion of game studies.